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Total Obedience

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Free media and discipleship resources for pastors, leaders, and growing disciples.

Total Obedience

Today's Reading: John 21:18-19

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

“ ‘When you were young, you used to dress yourself and walk wherever you wanted, but when you are old, you will stretch out your hands, and another will dress you and carry you where you do not want to go’ (This he said to show by what kind of death he was to glorify God.) And after saying this, he said to him, ‘Follow me.’”

* * * * *

Jesus had an important truth he wanted Peter to understand. When Peter was younger, before being called by Jesus, he had complete freedom. He could go where he wanted and do whatever he desired. He could dress himself the way he wanted without concern or worry. He had total autonomy.

But that would all change because of his total devotion to the Lord. A time was coming when he would be forced to stretch out his hands. Jesus was referring to Peter's future crucifixion. Someone would come and dress him to take him to his cross. He would be forced to go to a place where he didn't want to go.

He would face martyrdom for following Jesus.

Legend suggests that Peter asked his executioners that he be crucified upside down. He didn't think himself worthy to die in the same way his Lord had died. If true, it's a lovely affirmation of Peter's humility before he faced death.

Jesus then repeated to Peter what he had said when he first called Peter to be his disciple: “Follow me.” Once again, Peter was asked to put down his fishing nets and obey what Jesus was calling him to do.

Peter would go to where Jesus wanted him to go, and obey the Lord completely until the day he died.

Jesus' call upon your life is equally total and compelling. He wants you to obey him no matter what the cost—even if it means death. You have decided to follow the Lord. You've chosen to love him more than anything else in this fallen world. There is no turning back.

Follow the Lord Jesus Christ. Go and make disciples of all the nations. Be his witness everywhere you go. Live as he tells you to live. Obey all that he commanded you to do. Joyful are those who obey him and search for him with all their hearts. When you obey him, you will remain in his love.

When you follow Jesus, he promises he will be with you always, even to the close of the age. He assures you that no weapon formed against you will prosper. He will stand beside you and be your protective shade. You will remain in eternal fellowship with him. He will always be at your right hand. You will not be shaken.

As you obey God and keep his covenant, you will find that you are his treasured possession. This should inspire you to be faithful to him until the end of your life, to always obey his command to walk in love.

For giving your life to him, your reward in heaven will be great. All your righteous deeds will be revealed. And you will hear the applause of heaven.

You will be greatly blessed and honored for all eternity.

[from *"Hearing the Voice of God"* by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]